BASUDHA TRUST,
Rayagada, Odisha

Key person: **Debal Deb,** Founder, Conservation scientist

Year of inception: **2001 (Bankura campus), 2012 (Rayagada campus)**



BENEFICIARYSPEAK

"This rice has helped maintain my standing in our community. A hectare yields 24 quintals annually. When my relatives or friends visit and we serve it, they are overwhelmed by the aroma and taste"

KRUSHNA KAMHAR, *Farmer from Rayagada*

reduced this diversity, leaving only around 6,000 varieties extant today.

Around 17,000 farmers across eight Indian states have received rice seeds from Basudha, 7,000 of them in Odisha alone. These farmers do not pay for the seeds; instead, they agree to share the benefits with others. With this multiplier effect, another 20,000 farmers have taken up cultivation of these traditional rice forms, creating a grassroots network of biodiversity custodians. Prof. Subhasis Mondal, from the department of plant physiology, Bidhan Chandra Krishi Viswavidyalaya, says, "Basudha's conservation is not just on paper. It is through participatory farming, which helps these genes survive and grow."

Deb worked initially in Bankura, West Bengal, but the lack of interest among farmers there led him to relocate his conservation efforts to Odisha in 2012, where the work has flourished. Over the years, Basudha's seeds and conservation practices have gained popularity among farming communities not only in eastern India but in states such as Tamil Nadu, Kerala, Karnataka and Maharashtra, where farmers are reviving and cultivating ancestral rice varieties.

To collect the rare seeds, Deb has travelled across states, often in punishing conditions. On one such journey in Bengal, he travelled through relentless rain for a whole day to reach a remote village in Lataguri, in Jalpaiguri district. The goal: collect seeds of a near-forgotten rice variety, Agnishal. "That day," he remembers, "I was soaked to the bone. But I kept thinking—if I don't reach today, the seeds may disappear forever." It is this dedication that has built Basudha's identity in rice conservation circles all over the world. ■